## Federation of Recorded Music Societies

### Minutes of the Annual General Meeting held at the Royal Clifton Hotel & Spa, Southport on Saturday 8 November, 2014

Tom Smith, Chairman of Southport Gramophone Society welcomed delegates to the meeting and to Southport and introduced the Member of Parliament for Southport, Dr John Pugh who addressed the delegates, describing Southport as a Victorian seaside resort with a long liberal tradition. He himself had passionate interest in music, with a nostalgia for vinyl, although he observed that only CDs were on sale in the annexe to the meeting room. Listening to music in the company of like-minded people is a good thing. On a cautionary note, he advised delegates to keep an eye out for council parking wardens who tended to display a very mercenary attitude. He gave his wishes for a successful meeting.

FRMS Chairman Allan Child (Jubilee Music Circle(Derby)) thanked the MP for his welcome.

1. *Chairman's opening remarks* He enquired if the meeting was quorate; the Secretary replied that it was, with 19 delegates in attendance and 10 appointed proxies.
2. *Apologies for Absence* Apologies were received from the following affiliates who had nominated proxies: Barrow in Furness, Blackpool, Bury, Colwyn Bay, Huddersfield, New Forest, Ramsbottom, Spalding, Ulveston, Ulveston Jazz and Wolverhampton. Apologies were received from the following affiliates: Barnoldswick, CLPGS, Epsom, Lowestoft, Newcastle-upon-Tyne, Radlett, St Filan's, Sheffield, South Cheshire, Stockport, Stroud Valley, Wagner Society of Manchester and Winscombe. Apologies were received from the following individuals: Philip Ashton, Ron & Denise Beech, John & Rita Davies, Brian Godfrey, Thelma & Roderick Shaw and George Steele.
3. *Minutes of the Previous Annual General Meeting* The minutes of the Annual General Meeting held at Hinckley on 9 November 2013 had been circulated to all affiliates. Upon being put to the vote, the minutes were unanimously approved as a true and accurate record.
4. *Matters Arising from the Minutes* There were no matters arising from the Minutes.
5. *Chairman's Review* The Chairman, Allan Child (Jubilee Music Circle (Derby)), reported that, as delegates would have been aware, the loss of Chairman Colin Dancer, Vice-Chairman Roger Apps and our President Lyndon Jenkins within a very short space of time had significantly affected the Committee, but had not affected the service to affiliates in terms of licences, fees or advice, but it has increased the workload of those remaining. The Daventry Music Weekend was a success, in the planning of which Lyndon Jenkins had contributed a great deal; he and Colin Dancer would both have said the show must go on.

   With the impending well-deserved retirement after 11 years service as Honorary Treasurer, Graham Kiteley has been shadowed and assisted by Paul Corfield Godfrey in the preparation of quarterly accounts for the four Committee meetings held at Derby since the last AGM. A sub-committee held an extra meeting in Birmingham in August about the 2015 Daventry Music Weekend, reassigning roles to reflect the reduced Committee membership. The event will be on 24 to 26 April 2015.

   It is sad to report the demise of a further 9 affiliates since the last AGM; the total number is now 176. Nonetheless it is gratifying that despite reduced numbers and increasing age, so many societies are determined to continue.

   The content of the Bulletin has naturally had to reflect the Federation's *Annus Horribilis*, but continues under Editor Paul Astell to report positively on the activities of affiliates nationwide. He also strives to attract advertising and to maintain high production standards. The Committee has been made aware that not all members of affiliates see the magazine, and urges those on the mailing list to ensure that it is passed around all members.

   Webmaster George Steele continues to run the other main communication medium, the website (www.thefrms.co.uk) and is always willing to help affiliates.

   Other Committee members, Philip Ashton, Mick Birchall and Ron & Denise Beech have continued to perform their duties and helped to maintain Committee morale through a trying time.

   Secretary Jim Bostwick welcomes comments and enquiries in connection with the Federation, and is ready to offer support and advice. It is important that he is advised of personnel changes in order to maintain an accurate database.

   The Committee is still short of members and new recruits will be very welcome; meetings at the Brunswick Inn, Derby, are preceded by excellent ales and food.
6. *Annual Accounts & Treasurer's Report* The Retiring Treasurer, Graham Kiteley (CMS Kidderminster) presented his 11th (and final) Treasurer's Report; this had been circulated, and the salient points were: (i) it has been a steady year in all respects; the regular tasks included affiliation process, dealing with copyright and insurance matters and general management of the Federation finances. (ii) The past eight months has involved preparation for the transfer of the

Treasury function to the new Treasurer, Paul Corfield Gadfrey. He is confident that it will remain in good hands and that a similar level of support to affiliates will be maintained. (iii) The re-affiliation process, which has been handled by PCG, but is well advanced; he commended the hard core number of societies which had demonstrated the will and determination to survive despite reducing memberships. (iv) During his period in office he had endeavoured to contain charges to affiliates; on average four societies have closed per year, but none, to his knowledge, due to financial problems. (v) Total cash flow was down to £65 000; the Music Weekend accounted for just 25% of this. The overall surplus for the year of £1 800 was similar to the previous year, and represents a very satisfactory outcome. Detailed accounting papers were available for inspection by delegates. (vi) The policy of moving the AGM to venues around the country is reflected in varying costs; last year's meeting at Hinckley was a low cost event, the net charge of £500 representing just 10% of affiliation income, the usual measure. (vii) The Music Weekend generated a small surplus; reduced income was offset by reduced costs. Plans for the 2015 event are proceeding and it is hoped that an attractive programme will restore bookings and income. The ring-fenced reserve fund provides a cushion to protect the FRMS finances in the event of an adverse outcome. (viii) Thanks to the efforts of the Editor, Paul Astell, the Bulletin remains and attractive publication for affiliates. The surplus is down due to reduced advertising revenue and sales income, and some increase in distribution costs. Advertising is essential to its continued success; readers are urged to respond to advertisers and to always mention the Bulletin when doing so. (ix) General Administration costs do not merit detailed comment, beyond the saving in postal costs due to advance purchase of stamps last year. A similar tactic has been used this year which will benefit next year's accounts. A donation to a local hospice was made in memory of our late President, Lyndon Jenkins. (x) The Federation finances are in a healthy state, with reserves being necessary to cover periods of adverse cash flow. (xi) He recorded his gratitude to Committee colleagues for their support, and also all the affiliates with whom he had dealings over a variety of issues.

The Chairman thanked the Treasurer for his report and invited questions and comments.

(xii) Mick Birchall (Hinckley RMS) expressed the thanks on behalf of the FRMS at large for the quite outstanding job done by Graham Kiteley over the past eleven years as Treasurer, and for creating accounting procedures which will greatly assist his successor. (xiii) Bob Drew (CMS Kidderminster) asked why the Bulletin was not distributed by Royal Mail; the distribution was handled by the printers and was out of the hands of FRMS.

On the proposal of Mick Birchall (Hinckley RMS), seconded by Graham Ladley (Oswestry RMS), the adoption of the Annual Accounts and Treasurer's Report was unanimously approved, with the customary thanks and compliments for their comprehensiveness and clarity.

7. *Secretary's Report* The Secretary Jim Bostwick presented his third annual report and expressed his thanks to his Committee colleagues for their support and to the delegates whose attendance at the AGM gives legitimacy to the Federation. (i) The year had been exceptional: in the Federation's 78 year history it cannot have lost so many vital members in so short a period of time. However, the memories of Lyndon Jenkins, Colin Dancer and Roger Apps remain as an example to follow. (ii) Thanks to retiring Treasurer Graham Kiteley for his advice on a multitude of issues; the transfer of Treasury responsibility to Paul Corfield Godfrey has been seamless. (iii) Contact from affiliates has indicated persistent difficulties in filling key posts; the problem is most acute in the case of Treasurers when bank mandates have to be changed. Feedback from affiliates after such contacts would be appreciated. (iv) During the year under review eight affiliates had closed but one new group had just joined. The total number now stood at 176. A few societies report expanding memberships, Southport being one. The FRMS is always glad to receive good news. (v) An aim for the year ahead is to increase the number of affiliates contactable by e-mail to make communications cheaper and easier. affiliates and their members are urged to access the FRMS website, expertly managed by George Steel; it will play an increasingly important role in the future. (vi) The other major mode of communication with affiliates is the Bulletin. The Editor, Paul Astell, strives to make each issue relevant and interesting, and to make it self-supporting by raising advertising revenue. It was important that all members of affiliates had an opportunity to see it. With increasing mail costs an increasing amount of FRMS business matters will be included there. (vii) Two Committee vacancies remain; one new member, John Hardie (Southport GS) attended last year's AGM and subsequently attended some Committee meetings, and in consequence has been nominated (and welcomed) to the Committee; this pathway is open to any member of any affiliate. (viii) Similarly, offers had been invited to host the 2015 AGM; it would have been agreeable to report that he had been inundated with offers…… (ix) All Officers and Committee members had submitted valid nomination papers by the date required by clause 20 of the Constitution. Since no positions were contested a ballot was not required. (x) Following ratification of the new Officers and Committee, details will be communicated to Companies' House. (xi) The Secretary thanked Southport GS for hosting the AGM, and to John Hardie, their Secretary, for his great help in organising the event. (xii) He thanked Allan Child for stepping into the void left by the death of Colin Dancer, and whose steady hand had been a vital influence. (xiii) He hoped to see many of those present at the next big event, the Daventry Music Weekend on 24 to 26 April 2015.

The Chairman thanked the Secretary for his comprehensive report and invited questions and comments.

(xiv) Paul Astell (Oswestry RMS & Bulletin Editor) queried the number of delegates required to make a quorum. Tony Baines (Torbay RMS & Vice-president) replied that it was 10% of the total number of affiliates. (xv) Gavin Mist (York RMS) strongly commended the website and George Steele, the Webmaster.

Upon the proposal of Bett Steven (Maghull RMS), seconded by Kit Siddons-Smith (Southport GS) adoption of the Secretary's Report was approved unanimously.

8. *Confirmation of next year's Committee* A schedule of the names of Officers and Committee members had been circulated and upon the proposal of Tony Baines (Torbay RMS), seconded by Graham Ladley (Oswestry RMS) their confirmation was unanimously approved.
9. *Appointment of Independent Examiners* The Treasurer, Paul Corfield Godfrey thanked his predecessor Graham Kiteley for his help and reported that the Independent Examiners, Alvin Robinson BA, FCA and Malcolm Pye had carried out their task efficiently and punctually; both were eminently qualified and were willing to continue in office. He further advised that it was important for Examiners to be located as close as possible to the Treasuer to facilitate liaison. Thus far he had drawn a blank in South Wales but will continue to search; it may prove necessary to pay for this service in the future. In the meantime, to comply with the law, he recommended that the existing examiners be re-appointed pro tem. Upon the proposal of Graham Kiteley (CMS Kidderminster), seconded J Kennedy (Maghull RMS) the appointment of Alvin Robinson BA, FCA and Malcolm Pye was unanimously approved.
10. *Any Other Business* (i) Bob Drew (CMS Kidderminster) wished to place on record the thanks of website readers to George Steele; there was widespread verbal assent among the delegates. (ii) Graham Ladley (Oswestry RMS) thanked and commended the Chairman Allan Child, for his exemplary conduct of the meeting; there was widespread verbal assent among the delegates. (iii) Tom Smith (Southport GS) complimented FRMS in general, and the website in particular. (iv) Tony Baines (Torbay RMS & Vice-president) added his commendations to the retired Treasurer Graham Kiteley. (v) Gavin Mist (York RMS) enquired whether there is a model constitution for affliliates; there is. (vi) The Chairman advised that Chloë Hanslip and Danny Driver had been secured for the Sunday live music recital at the 2015 Daventry Music Weekend; their programme would include Beethoven's Sonata Op. 47 'Kreutzer'. (vii) There was no firm news yet as to the identity of the next President, but there are hopeful possibilities. A Newsletter will be published after the next Committee meeting.

    Before closing the meeting the Chairman thanked delegates for their attendance.

11. The meeting closed at 15:15.